

Management Skills

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Group 9

UPS IT Department Management Analysis

Part 1. Company Access and Background Information

The organization in which our team has secured access is United Parcel Service (UPS), more specifically, their IT department. This company believes that everyone has the ability to make an impact, and they do so by serving others and “moving our world forward by delivering what matters.” They describe themselves as “customer first, people-led, and innovation driven” with, as a global logistics leader, the responsibility to aid in building “safer, stronger, and more resilient communities founded on economic opportunity for all”. As a whole, this company is made up of about 490 thousand employees, serving in over 200 countries and territories. Within their technology department, there are approximately 9,300 employees. (United Parcel Service, n.d.)

As UPS is a global logistics company and within the parcel delivery sector, its major competitors are companies that deliver similar services. These include FedEx Corporation, DHL Group, and the United States Postal Service (USPS). Amazon Logistics has also become a competitor in the e-commerce industry. Specifically for the IT/AI department, their concern is with the IT/AI divisions of these companies. The team must deliver technology solutions and advancements that help UPS differentiate itself from competitors. (Grand View Research, n.d.) (DCL Logistics, n.d.)

When it comes to demographics, the total workforce gender diversity is 21.3% female and 78.7% male. Additionally, their workforce is made up of 50.5% White, 24% Black/African American, 18.8% Hispanic, 2.7% Asian, and 4% other. The company was ranked 1st for Hispanic/Latino diversity and 2nd for Black/African American diversity. When it comes to their Board members, however, statistics differ. The UPS Board of Directors is made up of 41.7%

female and 58.3% male individuals. White members make up 66.7% of the Board, Black/African American members make up 25%, and Asian individuals make up the remaining 8.3%. Among these members, the average age is 62.4 years old with the average tenure for existing members at 8.6 years. Having a proper level of diversity among the Board of Directors is extremely important when bringing about innovative thinking, sustainable business practices and effective decision making. (DriversIQ)

The global logistics market is very large; an estimate says it is about USD 3,794.4 billion in 2023, forecasted to hit USD 5,951 billion by 2030. Major players include FedEx, Deutsche Post DHL Group, and Amazon (Grand View Research). There are various recent business trends impacting this industry. There has been a boom in e-commerce, increasing demand for faster deliveries. Logistics firms thus have to invest in efficient technology, creating another trend of automated machinery, AI, and predictive analysis. There is also pressure to reduce carbon footprints by adopting electric vehicles and becoming more energy efficient (DCL Logistics). Furthermore, the logistics industry is very mature, as transportation, warehousing, and deliveries have been around for decades. However, the AI/IT sector is in transformation and is growing rapidly because it is fairly new. UPS is a well established organization, and its outlook remains positive with significant growth ahead. (Grand View Research, n.d.)

Part 2: Description of Data Collection and Summary of Interview and Survey Data

2a.

As mentioned, our group secured access with UPS's IT department. As a whole, this company is focused on supply chain logistics, with many specialty areas such as UPS Capital, freight forwarding, ground shipping, air shipping, and healthcare. The individuals we

interviewed are on the AI-focused side of the department. From this, we have learned that this division is federated, meaning “it is a shared responsibility across different business disciplines. It’s not a single team that performs AI. They have AI creation per business unit, meaning that they understand the business problems and they’re looking to adopt AI to solve inefficiencies”.

Our goal upon entering these interviews was to identify management-related issues in the department and learn from them by relating them to course concepts. Thus far, our team has interviewed three employees within UPS’s IT department. The first interview conducted took place in-person on October 18, 2025, from 4:00 pm to 4:39 pm. This interview was with Jeffery Kunz, a Principal AI engineer. This employee has a managerial role over our other two interviewees. This individual was chosen due to their important leadership role on the team and the countless responsibilities placed upon them on a day-to-day basis. The questions asked focused on their management style, communication, team structure, notable inefficiencies, and employee motivation and retention strategies. During all interviews, the interviewer took notes while an audio recording was also being made. This was then transcribed and provided to the rest of the team.

The two following interviews were with one of UPS’s AI architects and the lead machine learning engineer, both of whom work under Jeffrey Kunz. Both interviews were scheduled according to the employee’s availability, lasted approximately 15 minutes, and took place over Zoom. For these two interviews, 10-12 questions were created and altered to include inefficiencies noted in the first interview with UPS’ Principal AI Engineer, and asked to each. The first of these took place on Monday, October 20th, from 2:30 to 2:45 pm with Alex Marek, an AI architect at UPS. The second occurred on Tuesday, October 21st, from 4:00 to 4:15 pm with Alison Gacsi, a Lead Machine Learning Engineer. The interview questions focused on their

experience in their position, manager-employee dynamics, the effectiveness of motivation strategies, and inefficiencies/problems they have noted. To best understand these employees' roles in the company, Jeffrey Kunz provided the following analogy: In the case of building a house, the AI architect would focus on the blueprints and satisfying safety requirements, where the lead ML engineer is the foreman who builds the house.

Our team plans to conduct one additional follow-up interview with UPS's principal AI engineer. Although survey data was considered, our team determined that an in-depth interview with management itself would provide richer insights for the future of this project. Overall, collecting data from multiple levels of UPS' hierarchy enabled our team to see the ways in which management approaches and employee experiences may differ, further helping us pinpoint where gaps are occurring.

2b.

The main problems identified throughout these interviews included knowledge/skill gaps between management and technical teams, communication barriers, as well as a specialization vs. breadth conflict. Managers often lack hands-on experience when it comes to the new cutting-edge AI tools, making it difficult to give precise instructions to employees. More often than not, new technology evolves faster than leadership can learn it. This creates a work environment in which management provides their employees with an end goal/objective, and the employees have to figure out how to accomplish it without guidance. During the interview process, it was expressed that, depending on the project, this aspect of their dynamic can slow progress.

When it comes to communication barriers, both Ms. Gacsi and Mr. Marek expressed that messages and instructions lose clarity as they move up and down layers of management, especially when it comes to priorities. There are multiple layers of management that contribute to this, not the Principal AI Engineer himself. Lastly, Jeffrey Kunz went into detail regarding the ways in which teams are often put in frequent rotations that prevent them from mastering one niche. The goal of this is to expose employees in ways that help them continue to grow in diverse skillsets; however, Alex Marek expressed that although some employees like this approach, others feel frustrated that their attention is being taken away from their main task.

Focusing on the specifics of the knowledge gap dilemma, Jeffery Kunz explained that managing these new AI systems is challenging due to the fact that “when you’re the team adopting new technology, there’s no precedent.” He emphasized that this makes it difficult for management to give employees step-by-step direction. To help with this, he stated that they “focus on setting clear objectives, what outcome we want, rather than dictating every step.” In our interview with Alison Gacsi, the Lead Machine Learning Engineer, it was confirmed that the learning gap “can slow things down sometimes,” emphasizing that it’s “hard to change something like that because technology is growing so fast.” Alex Merek, an AI Architect, added to this by noting that even when he was in university, not nearly as long ago as upper management, courses did not exist that revolved around this new technology. He went on to state that “people are required to fill that role before people actually get educated on it. So I think it’s one of those push-and-pull challenges. The opportunity to educate on things will appear, but managers aren’t always going to be in practice to be up-to-date with everything.” One common factor across all three interviews was a clear gap in knowledge that people in those roles aren't

required to be educated on. There is no required training or learning sessions for pre-existing managers.

Based on this knowledge, the idea of training current employees was proposed by our team in the interviews. Alison Gacsi stressed that upper management, along with everyone else, would benefit from continuous training on new technologies because it “would help them understand the deliverables they’re asking for and help them plan out project timelines.” She went on to connect this problem solution directly to team efficiency, stating that “there are situations where timelines are set without knowing how much work happens behind the scenes.” Jeffrey Kunz also agreed that technical evolution forces management to depend on the expertise of each employee rather than formal guidance, further reinforcing the need for continual learning. This is especially interesting considering these employees expressed how even when they were in university, there were no classes to teach them these skills.

There were also deeper causes to the team’s communication barriers. Alex Marek noted that there are “too many layers of management,” stating that it causes miscommunication and reduces how much visibility he has on “bigger-picture asks.” Alison Gacsi also acknowledged that despite her immediate manager’s efficient communication, “sometimes timelines can get confusing when they come from very high up, since upper leadership has so many ideas at once, it’s hard to get them to prioritize.” Overall, these comments suggest that this specific issue stems less from their direct management and more from the organizational hierarchy itself.

Lastly, when it comes to the specialization vs. breadth conflict, Jeffrey Kunz described this as an ongoing balancing act. He stated that “teams rarely get to master one thing before pivoting. We try to make people well-rounded, but tight deadlines mean we rely on whoever can deliver fastest.” It was also described as a “double-edged sword” by Alex Marek, who explained

that although exposure to many areas broadens understanding, “there are certainly cases where that’s not very helpful, especially when we have tighter deadlines.” Alison Gacsi added that “It just gets difficult when you’re trying to balance multiple projects at once because it’s a lot of work to do your best across all of them”. She did, however, express mixed opinions, stating that switching projects often “helps you grow as a developer.”

When it comes to common themes among these problem areas, all three interviewees emphasized that mutual trust often helps compensate for knowledge gaps. Ms. Gacsi noted that “Our management trusts us now... they trust our experience.” Mr. Marek expressed a similar notion, stating that “trusting your talent is usually a key to success.” Jeffrey Kunz described his management approach as servant leadership, stating, “I set strategy and direction, but my main objective is removing blockers and using my organizational influence to get their cooperation from other departments.” There is also a need for streamlining and clearer processes. Ms. Gacsi suggested that consolidating procedures in an attempt to reduce inefficiency may help, expressing that “Right now, it can feel like different projects have different sets of rules. Consolidating that into a more streamlined process... would make things much easier.” Mr. Marek stated something similar, mentioning how the red tape and bureaucracy serve as restrictions and control “how change happens.” All members agreed that staying adaptable is the only way to move forward. Ms. Gacsi stated, “You’re never going to be able to hire somebody who knows everything that’s coming out... You just have to hire engineers that you trust can keep up.” Jeffrey Kunz described it as an environment where “you’re defining best practices yourself, constantly adjusting and learning the best way to use the technology.” Overall, it is clear that having strong relationships with team members helps with some inefficiencies; however, in the end, there is a significant gap in knowledge that may be preventing management

from fully guiding employees to their best abilities and setting up realistic deadlines that won't overwork them, leading to burnout. These issues highlight the importance of effective leadership, communication, and continuous learning.

Part 3: Preliminary Concept Identification

The team task design highlights the way the team's work is structured, set up, and assigned within the team. It decides the level of autonomy the employees have, the skills they are required to possess, and if the team displays meaningful work throughout the whole process of the project. In the AI department, there is a lack of technical depth for some managers. This causes task design to focus more toward outcome-based objectives instead of prescriptive step-by-step instructions. This gives employees the freedom to discover how they can generate results on their own. Nonetheless, certain task design alternatives can create tension within the team. To build better cross-functional proficiency, the team should be frequently rotated; this ensures that aggressive deadlines can be met efficiently.

Organizational structure creates the framework for coordination mechanisms, reporting lines, and authority structures that govern how the members work together. Vertical complexity within this hierarchy measures the number of management layers that live between top leadership and frontline employees. In particularly complex organizations, this information passes through multiple levels as it moves through the chain of command. Each layer can establish distortion due to messages being lost in translation. This communication creates tailbacks, which slow decision-making, causing costly problems for teams dealing with urgent deadlines in the future.

The data effectively illustrates how the company used Team Task Design, especially when it comes to giving teams freedom and granting them the ability to focus on separate tasks. Manager Jeffery Kunz explained that they organize their work around “AI creation per business unit,” which entails that each team works on its own project with a clear goal. Since technology is changing so rapidly, Kunz mentioned that the company’s main goal is to “focus on setting clear objectives of outcome rather than setting a step-by-step process,” which gives the teams a lot of independence. However, Kunz also mentioned that it can be difficult for each team to specialize in the AI domain because “teams rarely get to master one thing before pivoting.” Other employees have agreed with this statement. Alison Gacsi stated that she and her coworkers are often “moved between projects,” which can potentially cause tasks to be completed more slowly due to the knowledge gaps. Furthermore, Alex Marek addressed that consistently switching projects “is not very helpful, especially when we have tighter deadlines.”

Vertical complexity within the company focuses on how communication moves through the different levels of management. Manager Jeffery Kunz explained that the AI division is built in a “federated” way and stated that his job is to “remove blockers and use my organizational influence to get their cooperation from other departments,” which demonstrates how he needs to operate through different layers within the organization. Furthermore, each employee dealt with the effects of this complex structure. Alex Marek confessed that there are “too many layers of management,” which causes him to find it frustrating to understand “bigger-picture asks,” which leads to miscommunication within the hierarchy. Additionally, Alison Gacsi agreed with his words; she states that “sometimes timelines can get confusing when they come from very high up... It's hard to get them to prioritize.” This evidence indicates that having many layers in the hierarchy can cause confusion within the line, making things harder to manage.

The first course concept is Team Task Design. Based on our interviews with the AI department, one of the main questions is switching projects frequently and unclear specialization. It makes the efficiency low and limits personal ability improvement. And each staff member cannot find their role in the team. For example, manager Jeffrey said, “Teams rarely get to master one thing before moving on,” and employee Alison mentioned that “tight timelines and dual projects working at the same time make coordination difficult.” According to Team Task Design theory, the effective team relies on how structured the team members are and the teamwork between teammates. The well teams should own clear roles, balanced interdependence, and enough time for team members to grow in their positions. Although the members in UPS are flexible, which can improve creativity, it confuses team roles and makes it difficult to learn knowledge deeply or improve skills. The members must adapt to new teams quickly, which makes it hard to get balanced interdependence. In conclusion, the Team Task Design theory helps explain the team problem. UPS's flexible team system hurts efficiency and team members' personal growth. To improve the present situation, UPS should keep the core members of the projects and rotate other members as needed. And when other team members grow up, UPS can make them become new core members. After that, the core members know their roles and maintain balanced interdependence with each other. And other members can train their ability. The new system can still keep the creativity while also allowing time for UPS.

The second course concept is Vertical Complexity. From the interview with the UPS AI department, we find the key issue is slow communication and decision-making. One decision approval needs multiple management levels. That prevents the project from moving forward. For instance, Marek mentioned that there is “a lot of red tape and bureaucracy in the company,” and Gacsi said, “The timelines often become confusing because too many responses form layers in

the organization.” According to the concept of Vertical Complexity, the more management levels in an organization, the harder it becomes to get projects promoted. UPS’s AI department uses a federated model, where every unit owns its AI managers. It helps coordination between teams that every team owns AI managers, but also increases vertical complexity, which makes communication and approval slower. As manager, Kunz mentioned he tried to remove the political barriers for his team. To solve the problem, UPS should simplify the approval process or reduce unnecessary management earlier, which can make the timeline of projects shorter. In conclusion, the Vertical Complexity helps explain UPS’s communication and coordination issues. As UPS solves the problem, it can make faster decisions and respond to problems earlier.

Part 4. Recommendations

1. Two Recommendations

(1a): Course Concept: Team Task Design

Our first recommendation would be that UPS should design a core-team and rational support model to reduce switching costs and increase specialization. Steady core teams should be established for each active AI team project. Each team would consist of 3-5 members who will be assigned within that team for the project cycle. Additionally, each team member should consider rotating other engineers in and out of the team when they're needed for certain specialized tasks. If the managers clarify each member's responsibilities and address which roles may rotate, then the team gains valuable learning opportunities without compromising the consistency or productivity of the project.

To do this, UPS should establish a defined project-cycle structure where core members remain assigned for a minimum of 8-12 weeks. Individuals would be rotations only at pre-planned checkpoints that are coordinated by the Principal AI Engineer. Every individual

role should have a written responsibility overview. When new members are rotated in, they should receive a short briefing that outlines the current progress, outstanding tasks, and technical context. UPS should also introduce weekly core team progress meetings to maintain stability across the project timeline. These concrete steps would help ensure that specialization is protected all the while enabling employees to gain controlled, purposeful cross-functional exposure.

As stated by employees Jeffery and Alison, “Teams rarely get to master one thing before pivoting,” and “balancing multiple projects at once is a lot of work.” Having a core-team structure will help resolve UPS’s inefficiencies while maintaining cross-functional growth. This strategy addresses burnout risks, confusion across project teams, and slower timelines that are created from continuous reassignment within the organization.

Additionally, establishing these sets of core teams help mitigate the knowledge and skill gap amongst much of upper management and their employees. When managers consistently work with the same group during a full project cycle, they would have opportunities to gain deeper exposure to emerging AI tools and workflows, ultimately improving their ability to set realistic timelines and provide clearer guidance. This helps address one of the most critical inefficiencies identified in the interview process.

(1b) Course Concept: Vertical Complexity

Since there have been consistent communication delays voiced, as well as message distortion, UPS should establish a two-tier communication protocol. This protocol could include a first channel for standardized communication in which strategic updates for managers from the senior leadership would be sent. Implementation would involve creating

centralized communications hubs where senior leadership would post weekly project priorities, timelines, and clarification on higher-level goals. Within these hubs, only designated decision makers, such as their Principal AI Engineer, would be able to post this content. This would ensure clarity and prevent an overload of unnecessary uploads. The channel should also include pinned guidance on escalation procedures and approval timelines in order to decrease delays that are caused by excessive hierarchical layers.

The second channel would be a more clear and simplified approval pathway, where there is a limited amount of managerial layers involved. UPS should formalize a two-step approval process for technical decisions. The first would be direct approval from the Principal AI Engineer for technical methods, and the second would be a final confirmation from the director-level manager when their budget or external dependencies are intertwined with the project. All other immediate managers should be bypassed for routine or low-risk decisions. Overall, this would reduce unnecessary back and forth communication and prevent messages from getting distorted in the ways two of their employees described in our interviews.

To sum, this channel would be used mainly for technical decisions, to avoid confusion and too many voices for simple decisions. This specific recommendation will help to combat the complaints of UPS employees, who mentioned inconsistent signals from too many levels of management. As seen in the vertical complexity theory, the more levels of an organization's hierarchy information goes through, the more likely it is to be distorted and delayed. This streamlined system would help to reduce ambiguity and speed-up decision making.

2. Management Best Practices

Recommendation 1:

Organizations struggling in environments with frequent job transfers and high transition costs have attempted a "structured small team" approach similar to what we proposed for UPS. A representative example is Spotify's "squad" model - they form small and stable teams focused on long-term projects and only temporarily call in other professionals when special tasks require it (Bain & Company, n.d.; Atlassian, n.d.). Each team's responsibilities are clear, and everyone knows what they should do. This approach allows members to truly invest and utilize their professional abilities, while also enabling cross departmental collaboration when necessary to create more value. Spotify's experience has also confirmed that a stable core team can significantly reduce chaos and inefficiency. And these are precisely the pain points repeatedly mentioned by UPS employees in interviews.

Another example is Google, which arranges several weeks of engineering sprints and fixes team tasks. Engineers will work on the same project for a full cycle, and rotation will only occur at scheduled times. Newly joined members will receive a concise written summary that outlines project progress, technical background, and remaining work, which will help them get started faster. This approach not only helps everyone maintain professional depth, but also allows managers to have a clearer understanding of the team's operations. Google's experience also confirms the solution we proposed for UPS: planned rotation and clear division of responsibilities can protect productivity and reduce fatigue - even in fast-paced and ever-changing technological environments, it can make the team more stable and efficient.

These examples show that: maintaining team stability, arranging planned rotations, and making everyone's responsibilities clear are truly effective practices. They also make our suggestions more convincing. This core team model can greatly assist organizations like UPS that face coordination challenges and heavy workloads to operate more efficiently and easily.

Recommendation 2:

Large organizations will sometimes adopt a "two-tier communication" approach similar to the one we recommended for UPS. A good example is Amazon's "single-layer leadership," in which the model is that for each project, it has a clear person in charge who is responsible for releasing strategic updates (Business Insider, 2025). By restricting who can send messages, Amazon can prevent misinformation and keep messages clear within the organization. This also reduces the delay caused by too many levels. Amazon's experience has provided us with confidence in recommending UPS to establish a centralized and controlled communication center - this approach does indeed work in complex environments.

Toyota is also a relevant example, as they have a standardized communication system. Tools like A3 reports and Andon dashboards keep the information conveyed by senior management consistent, organized, and easy to understand. Strategic information will be officially released, while daily operational decisions will be quickly processed by the front line, requiring almost no tedious approval. Separating strategic information from technological decision-making paths can reduce ambiguity and prevent information from being distorted in hierarchical transmission. Toyota's practice once again confirms our

advice to UPS: dividing communication channels reasonably and reducing unnecessary levels can really make decisions faster and clearer (Lean Enterprise Institute, n.d.).

Formalizing strategic communication and streamlining technical decision-making procedures can be quite beneficial in large firms with intricate hierarchical structures. Reducing vertical complexity can successfully solve the problems of delays, uncertainty, and contradictory information identified by UPS employees during interviews.

3. Recommendation Downsides

Recommendation #1:

While establishing core teams with structured rotations may strengthen the specialization within groups at UPS and reduce inefficiencies, there are several potential factors that could negatively impact the organization. One risk is that the recommendation may not work if UPS' unpredictable project demands require more frequent reassignment. This would make it more difficult to maintain stable core teams for 8 to 12 weeks. With how fast AI driven environments are moving, urgent priorities may force managers to break the cycles early, ultimately limiting the intended benefits. A second consideration would be the cost. Implementing this model requires additional manager time, administrative planning, coordination of checkpoint rotations, and the creation of written responsibility outlines and onboarding briefings. All of these things would take over hours of labor from the employees at UPS who are already busy with their technical and leadership roles. Lastly, another possible unintended consequence is that employees may feel boxed into certain roles. This could reduce their exposure to diverse skill sets and slow their long-term career development. Some members within the teams may also perceive core team assignments as favoritism if they

think that certain individuals consistently receive more desirable projects. If this is not communicated and managed carefully, the structure could lead to an unintentional decrease in morale or even worse burnout by increasing pressure on core members to deliver consistently through long-term project cycles.

Recommendation #2:

Implementing a two-tiered communication protocol and centralized communication channels could streamline the flow of information, however, it could also come with some potential drawbacks. One risk associated with this is the fact that the system may not work as intended if senior leadership or mid-level managers fail to consistently use the designated channels. This could cause employees to revert back to informal communication pathways that could reintroduce much confusion and message distortion. A measurable cost is the time and resources required to build, train, and enforce the new communication structure. Different departments within UPS may need to adopt new software tools, provide training sessions, and establish monitoring processes to ensure compliance. An unintended consequence is that restricting posting permissions to only designated decision makers could unintentionally silence vulnerable input from experienced employees such as engineers or frontline staff. UPS' employees may hesitate to raise issues or clarify priorities outside of the structured channels. In turn, this could delay urgent decisions or hide emerging problems. Additionally, bypassing intermediate managers during technical approvals could make some supervisors feel excluded or undermined, potentially creating tension within the hierarchy of UPS, rather than resolving it.

It is important to note, however, that despite these possible downsides and difficulties that UPS may run into during the process of implementing our recommendations, during a

followup interview with Jeffery Kunz, the Principal AI Engineer, stated that there was definite potential for a positive change within our recommendations, if implemented correctly.

4. Communicating Our Findings

We can use two things we learned in the Week 9 lecture to get UPS to agree with us: authority and consistency.

When people are in charge, they are more likely to listen to experts or tried-and-true methods. The Spotify squad model and the Google project-cycle system are two ways that our ideas work. Both of these systems have stable core teams that switch places every so often. There aren't a lot of levels of management at Amazon or Toyota, so it's easy for them to talk to each other. UPS workers talked about issues like not knowing when things were due, having to switch projects a lot, and taking too long to make decisions. When we see that big companies use ideas like ours, we are more likely to believe and trust them.

According to consistency, people usually like actions that are in line with their current values. UPS likes to say that "people, customers, and new ideas" are what keep it going. The things we tell you to do will help you get there. For example, stable core teams help employees grow and avoid burnout, and better communication helps UPS reach its goals of coming up with new ideas and getting more done. The suggestions make sense for UPS because they are in line with what UPS already thinks.

If we follow these two rules, UPS will likely be more incentivized to agree with us.

Part 5. Bibliography, Endnotes & Appendices

Bibliography

The following sources were used to support the analysis, theory integration, and recommendations presented in this report. All external scholarly, business, and organizational sources are cited in APA format and were essential for validating our findings.

Endnotes

1. Insights from UPS's Principal AI Engineer, AI Architect, and Lead Machine Learning Engineer informed the identification of core management challenges, including communication delays, knowledge gaps, and frequent team rotations.
2. Course concepts such as Team Task Design, Vertical Complexity, and Week 9 Influence Principles were directly applied to interpret interview findings and develop recommendations.
3. Best practice examples from Spotify, Google, Amazon, and Toyota were chosen because their structures mirror the issues UPS currently faces, strengthening the Authority principle in our persuasion strategy.
4. Considerations of risks, costs, and unintended consequences were shaped by both interview comments and common patterns found in organizational behavior research.
5. All interview questions and the full contact log are included in the appendix to meet project transparency requirements.

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Appendix

Full Interview Questions

Interview 1 (Jeffrey Kunz | Manager) Questions:

1. Can you describe UPS’s AI and Machine Learning division—its main mission and how it fits into UPS’s larger technology strategy?
2. What would you consider the company’s main mission overall?
3. What are the primary goals or ongoing projects within your team right now?
4. So your team works alongside them to find out what their inefficiencies are?
5. So the cross-border shipping and internal productivity projects are what your team is working on right now?
6. Is part of your role managing each of these subgroups?

7. How is the team structured—for example, engineers, architects, and data scientists?
8. How does your team collaborate with other departments or business units?
9. What are some current trends or challenges you see in applying AI and machine learning within logistics?
10. When it comes to leading your team as a whole, what are your biggest challenges?
11. How do employees respond to that management approach?
12. What do you do to help keep employees motivated and engaged?
13. What about maintaining morale on a daily basis?
14. Do you implement smaller, achievable goals to reach larger ones?
15. How would you describe your leadership style?
16. Do you do anything for motivation outside of project work?
17. How do you handle communication, feedback, or performance reviews?
18. What could improve team performance and communication?
19. What about the two other employees I'll be interviewing?
20. How does your management approach differ with employees who aren't as reliable?
21. How do you respond when employees disagree with your direction?
22. How do you handle disengagement when you notice it?
23. How do you adapt your management style for new interns or hires?

Interview 2 (Alex Marek | Employee) Questions:

1. What is your role on the AI and Machine Learning team, and what kinds of projects are you currently working on?

2. In my previous interview, it was mentioned that management doesn't always have the newest technical skills when it comes to new technologies like AI. Do you find those management limitations difficult?
3. If you could do anything to improve challenges that might come from that information gap, what would it be?
4. What would you say are your biggest day-to-day challenges in your role?
5. How does your team typically handle tight deadlines, model performance issues, and competing project priorities?
6. Do you feel your ideas and feedback are heard when decisions are made about projects or direction?
7. What changes or improvements could be made to make the team, work environment, or management style more effective and satisfying?
8. What motivates you to do your best work at UPS?
9. Have you noticed employees who may have less internal drive than you? If so, do you notice differences in management styles used to motivate them?
10. How are conflicts or differing opinions usually handled within the team?
11. Do you feel supported in your professional growth and learning by management?
12. In my previous interview, it was mentioned that some teams have difficulty specializing because assignments change often. Do you think that system prevents people from becoming their best in a certain area?
13. Does this create a more well-rounded group overall?

Interview 3 (Alison Gacsi | Employee) Questions:

1. Can you describe your role at UPS, and what kinds of projects are you currently working on?
2. In a previous interview, it was expressed that management does not have the technical skills and experience with new upcoming technology, and therefore are only really able to provide you with an end goal that you must figure out how to achieve on your own. Do you find the management restrictions when it comes to new technology, such as Ai, difficult?
3. Can you describe a time in which this information gap got in the way of progress and what you would change to make it more efficient?
4. How would you describe the workflow and communication between you and your manager(s)?
5. Do you feel your ideas and feedback are heard when decisions are made about projects or direction?
6. What changes or improvements could make the team's work environment and management style more effective or satisfying?
7. How are conflicts or differing opinions usually handled within the team?
8. What motivates you to do your best work here?
9. Are UPS' social gatherings such as ping pong and ice cream socials effective at bringing employees together and increasing motivation? And if not, what would you change?
10. What advice would you give to your management to improve efficiency and employee motivation?
11. Do you think information and goals from upper management are clearly communicated to your team? Are there times when messages or priorities get lost between layers?

12. In a previous interview, it was mentioned that UPS tends to give various projects to teams in the attempt of exposing them to multiple areas of the field. Do you feel that the lack of specialization prevents employees from reaching their full potential in their main tasks?

Interview 4 (Jeffrey Kunz | Manager) Questions:

1. Upon viewing our initial deliverable, what were your thoughts?
2. Do you believe that our work adequately reflects the situations occurring at UPS?
3. Is there anything you would personally change about the information we presented?
4. When it comes to future recommendations, what do you think of the two focusing on team task design and vertical complexity that I outlined for you?
5. Do you believe that if done correctly, these recommendations could improve employee experiences at UPS?

Individuals Interviewed

1. Jeffrey Kunz (Manager – Principal AI Engineer)
2. Alex Marek (Employee – AI Architect)
3. Alison Gacsi (Employee – Lead Machine Learning Engineer)

Contact Log

1. UPS IT Division Principal AI Engineer Jeffrey Kunz Interview: In-person meeting
Saturday, October 18th, 4:00 PM - 4:39 PM
2. UPS IT Division Interview AI architect Alex Marek: Zoom meeting Monday, October
20th, 2:30 PM - 2:45 PM
3. UPS IT Division Interview Lead ML Engineer Alison Gacsi: Zoom meeting October
21st, 4:00 PM - 4:15 PM

4. UPS IT Division Principal AI Engineer Jeffrey Kunz Interview: Zoom meeting Friday,
November 21st, 8:00 PM - 8:10 PM